

Dali 5-Day Budget Travel Plan

Extreme Budget: 500 RMB/person total · 5 Adults · May 18-22

Prepared: 2026-05-14 | Note: This plan requires extreme cost control measures.

1. Budget Reality Check

5 people × 500 RMB = 2,500 RMB total for ALL expenses. Typical Dali 5-day trip costs 1,000-2,000/person. This plan targets the absolute minimum.

Transport Option	Round Trip/Pers	Remaining Budget	Feasibility
■ Self-drive (Chongqing→Dali)	~260 RMB	240 RMB	■■■■ Recommended
■ Overnight Hard Sleeper Train	~210 RMB	290 RMB	■■■■ Feasible
■ High-speed Rail	~460 RMB	- (over budget)	■ Not feasible

Assumption: Departing from Chongqing area. If already in Yunnan (Kunming etc.), costs decrease significantly.

2. Day-by-Day Itinerary

DAY 1 — May 18 (Mon) · Arrive + Dali Old Town Night

Time	Activity	Cost/pers
08:00-16:00	Depart Chongqing → Dali (self-drive ~8h / train arrival) + transport	
16:00-17:00	Check into hostel, drop luggage	
17:00-18:00	Wander Dali Old Town (FREE)	0
18:00-19:00	Dinner: cold rice noodles + roast milk fan (street food)	~15
19:00-21:00	Night view: Wuhua Tower, Foreigner Street (FREE)	0
■ Accommodation	Youth hostel bed (30-50 RMB/night)	~40

DAY 2 — May 19 (Tue) · Erhai West Bank Cycling

Time	Activity	Cost/pers
06:30-07:30	Sunrise at Longkan/ Caicun Pier (FREE)	0
07:30-12:00	Bike rental along Erhai Eco Corridor (20-30/day)	20
12:00-13:00	Lunch: local stall mixian / bring own food	10
13:00-16:00	Continue cycling, photo stops	0
16:00-18:00	Rest at hostel, rest	0
18:00-19:00	Dinner: cook at hostel kitchen / cheap snacks	8
■ Accommodation	Same youth hostel	40

DAY 3 — May 20 (Wed) · Xizhou Ancient Town

Time	Activity	Cost/pers
09:00-10:00	Bus: Old Town → Xizhou (7 RMB)	7

Time	Activity	Cost/pers
10:00-12:30	Explore Xizhou: corner tower, Bai folk houses (FREE)	0
12:30-13:30	Lunch: Xizhou baba pie (3-5) + cold noodles	8
13:30-16:00	Xizhou rice fields walk / coffee shop people watch	0
16:00-17:00	Bus back to Old Town	7
17:00-19:00	Rest, evening stroll Old Town	0
19:00-20:00	Dinner: cheap noodle shop	12
■ Accommodation	Youth hostel	40

DAY 4 — May 21 (Thu) · Cangshan Hike + Jizhao Nunnery (FREE Meal!)

Time	Activity	Cost/pers
08:00-09:00	Walk to Cangshan base (skip cable car, hike free trail)	0
09:00-11:00	Hike to Jizhao Nunnery (lovely garden temple)	0
11:30-12:00	■ FREE vegetarian lunch at Jizhao Nunnery	0
12:00-14:00	Explore Dali University area / walk back	0
14:00-17:00	Free time: Old Town cafes, photo spots	0
18:00-19:00	Dinner: cook together / street skewers	10
■ Accommodation	Last night at hostel	40

DAY 5 — May 22 (Fri) · Departure

Time	Activity	Cost/pers
08:00-09:00	Breakfast: spicy bean soup + fried dough sticks	6
09:00-10:00	Pack, check out, souvenir shopping (skip if tight)	0
10:00-18:00	Drive / train back to Chongqing	In transport

3. Detailed Cost Breakdown

Scenario A: Self-Drive (Recommended)

Item	Total (5 ppl)	Per Person
Fuel (1800km round trip)	800 RMB	160
Toll (Chongqing-Kunming-Dali)	500 RMB	100
Hostel (40 RMB/bed × 4 nights)	200	160
Food (60 RMB/pers × 5 days)	300	60
Bike rental (1 day)	100	20
Local bus	70	14
TOTAL	1,970 RMB	~514

≈514/person — 14 RMB over budget. Very tight but possible with minor cuts.

Scenario B: Overnight Train (Hard Sleeper)

Item	Total (5 ppl)	Per Person
Train ticket (~105 RMB × 2 ways)	1,050	210
Hostel (40 RMB × 4 nights)	200	160
Food (60 RMB × 5 days)	300	60
Bike + local bus	170	34
TOTAL	1,720	~464

≈464/person — within budget! But 18+ hours on train each way.

4. Extreme Budget Tips

- **Hostel Dorm Bed** — Book a 4-6 person dorm for ~40/night. Save even more by asking for weekly rate.
- **Jizhao Nunnery FREE Lunch** — Legendary free vegetarian meal. Be respectful, arrive before 11:30.
- **Cook at Hostel** — North Gate Market has cheap fresh produce. Many hostels offer kitchen access.
- **Free Attractions Rule** — Dali Old Town, Erhai lakeside, Xizhou, Jizhao, Dali University — all FREE.
- **Skip Paid Sites** — Three Pagodas (75), Cangshan Cable Car (80-120), Butterfly Spring — skip them all.
- **Bring Water Bottle** — Refill at hostel. Save 3-5/day on drinks.
- **Street Food is King** — Mixian (rice noodles) 8-12, Ersi 6-8, Baba pie 3-5. Avoid restaurant sit-downs.
- **Bike Negotiation** — Group of 5, negotiate from 30 to 20/day per bike.
- **Weather Check** — May 18-22: 18-28°C, sunny. Pack light + one jacket for evenings.

5. Important Notes

- Prices are estimates as of May 2026. Actual costs may vary.
- May is pre-summer season — book hostel at least 3 days ahead.
- Self-drive route: Chongqing → Zunyi → Guiyang → Kunming → Dali (~8h). Use navigation app for real-time tolls.
- Train option: Chongqing West → Kunming (hard sleeper ~6h, ~100 RMB) + Kunming → Dali (high-speed 2h, ~110 RMB).
- Bring student ID if applicable for discounts.
- Plan B: If budget is too tight, consider cutting to 4 days and save one night of accommodation.

— End of Report —